

Word family: **menu / menus**

Base word: menu

Plural: menus

Part of speech: noun (名詞)

For a learner database, **menu** is overwhelmingly a noun. Its important polysemy comes from the expansion:

> **list of food choices → list of choices generally → selectable list in a computer/device interface**

Major compounds/constructions:

- * restaurant menu
- * handwritten menu
- * menu card
- * menu item
- * menu section
- * menu board
- * set menu
- * fixed-price menu
- * prix-fixe menu
- * à-la-carte menu
- * tasting menu
- * degustation menu
- * table-d'hôte menu
- * children's / kids' menu
- * dessert menu
- * drinks / beverage menu
- * wine menu
- * cocktail menu
- * breakfast / lunch / dinner menu
- * seasonal menu
- * special menu
- * secret menu
- * off-menu item
- * on the menu
- * off the menu
- * menu of choices/options/services
- * main menu
- * submenu
- * menu bar
- * menu item
- * drop-down menu
- * pull-down menu
- * pop-up menu

- * context menu
- * hamburger menu
- * navigation menu
- * settings menu
- * Start menu
- * pause menu
- * DVD/disc menu
- * boot menu
- * voice / phone menu
- * menu-driven
- * menu engineering
- * menu design
- * menu costs

Your passage:

> “Many people imagine warm lighting, the handwritten **menu** and the smell of fresh pastries...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **menu** means:

> **the written or printed list of food and drinks a café offers customers, often including prices and descriptions.**

The adjective **handwritten** specifically emphasizes the physical/design side:

> a menu whose dish names, prices, etc. appear in handwriting or a handwritten visual style.

繁體中文：

* **餐牌** — very natural in Hong Kong

* **菜單**

* **餐單**

So:

> “the handwritten menu”

= **「手寫餐牌」 / 「手寫菜單」**

The passage uses it as part of an idealized café image:

> warm lighting + handwritten menu + pastries

> = the attractive, romantic surface of café ownership.

A. MENU = LIST OF FOOD AND DRINK AVAILABLE

1. **menu = list of dishes/drinks available in a restaurant (餐牌 ; 菜單) **

The central meaning.

> “Can I see the menu?”

「我可以看看**餐牌**嗎？」

> “The menu includes several vegetarian dishes.”

「餐牌上有幾款素食菜式。」

A restaurant menu commonly tells customers:

- * what is available;

- * prices;

- * descriptions;

- * ingredients;

- * categories.

B. MENU = THE PHYSICAL DOCUMENT

2. **menu = the card/booklet/sheet on which restaurant offerings are written (餐牌本身) **

> “The waiter handed us two menus.”

「侍應給了我們兩份**餐牌**。」

Here **menu** refers to the physical objects.

Compare:

> “The menu has changed.”

This probably means:

> the **offerings/content** changed,

not that the paper itself changed.

So **menu** has a useful metonymic distinction:

physical menu

the document/display.

menu content

the food and drink choices listed on it.

C. HANDWRITTEN MENU

3. **handwritten menu = 手寫餐牌**

Your exact phrase.

Can mean literally:

> written by hand

or commercially:

> designed to look handwritten.

It often creates an impression of:

* intimacy;

* craftsmanship;

* informality;

* small independent café culture.

D. MENU CARD

4. **menu card = 餐牌 / 菜單卡**

Used in some varieties of English for the physical menu.

In ordinary restaurant English, simply:

> **menu**

is usually sufficient.

E. MENU ITEM

5. **menu item = one individual food/drink offering (餐牌項目 ; 菜式) **

> “This is our most popular menu item.”

「這是我們最受歡迎的**餐牌菜式**。」

A menu item can be:

- * dish;
- * drink;
- * side;
- * dessert;
- * package.

F. MENU SECTION / CATEGORY

6. **menu section = 餐牌分類**

Examples:

- * starters
- * mains
- * sides
- * desserts
- * drinks

G. MENU DESCRIPTION

7. **menu description = 菜式描述**

The wording explaining a dish's:

- * ingredients;
- * preparation;
- * accompaniments;
- * flavour.

H. MENU PRICE

8. **menu price = 餐牌標價**

> “The menu price does not include service.”

「餐牌標價未包括服務費。」

I. MENU BOARD

9. **menu board = 菜單展示板 / 餐牌板**

Common in:

- * cafés;
- * fast-food outlets;
- * food stalls.

Can be:

- * chalkboard;
- * printed board;
- * digital display.

J. DIGITAL MENU

10. **digital menu = 電子餐牌**

A menu displayed on:

- * screen;
- * tablet;
- * kiosk;
- * website.

K. QR-CODE MENU

11. **QR menu / QR-code menu = 掃碼餐牌**

Customers scan a QR code to view the menu digitally.

L. ONLINE MENU

12. **online menu = 網上餐牌**

Menu published on:

- * restaurant website;
- * app;
- * ordering platform.

M. DELIVERY / TAKEAWAY MENU

13. **delivery menu = 外賣配送餐牌**

Items offered specifically for delivery may differ from dine-in offerings.

14. **takeaway / takeout menu = 外賣餐牌**

BrE:

> takeaway menu

AmE:

> takeout menu.

N. BREAKFAST / LUNCH / DINNER MENU

15. **breakfast menu = 早餐餐牌**

16. **lunch menu = 午餐餐牌**

17. **dinner menu = 晚餐餐牌**

Restaurants may change menus according to service period.

O. BRUNCH MENU

18. **brunch menu = 早午餐餐牌**

P. DESSERT MENU

19. **dessert menu = 甜品餐牌**

Sometimes provided separately after the main meal.

Q. DRINKS / BEVERAGE MENU

20. **drinks menu / beverage menu = 飲品餐牌**

May include:

- * coffee;
- * tea;
- * juice;
- * soft drinks;
- * alcoholic drinks.

R. WINE MENU / WINE LIST

21. **wine menu = 葡萄酒餐牌**

However:

> **wine list**

is often the more idiomatic traditional restaurant expression.

S. COCKTAIL MENU

22. **cocktail menu = 雞尾酒餐牌**

A specialized drinks menu.

T. CHILDREN'S / KIDS' MENU

23. **children's menu / kids' menu = 兒童餐牌**

Usually offers:

- * smaller portions;
- * simpler dishes;
- * child-oriented choices.

U. VEGETARIAN / VEGAN MENU

24. **vegetarian menu = 素食餐牌**

25. **vegan menu = 純素餐牌**

Can mean:

- * entire restaurant offering;
- * separate menu;
- * special set of choices.

V. SEASONAL MENU

26. **seasonal menu = 季節餐牌**

Menu that changes with:

- * season;
- * produce availability;
- * festivals;
- * weather.

W. LIMITED MENU

27. **limited menu = 選擇較少的餐牌**

Can be intentional to:

- * simplify operations;
- * control costs;
- * specialize.

X. SPECIAL MENU

28. **special menu = 特別餐牌 / 限定餐單**

Prepared for a particular:

- * event;
- * holiday;
- * occasion;
- * promotion.

Y. À LA CARTE MENU

29. **à-la-carte menu = 單點餐牌**

Each dish is selected and normally priced separately.

> “We ordered from the à-la-carte menu.”

「我們從**單點餐牌**點菜。」

Contrast:

> set menu.

Z. SET MENU

30. **set menu = 套餐 / 固定餐單**

A predetermined combination or selection of courses, usually offered for one price. ([Toast POS]
[1])

Example:

> starter + main + dessert.

Often some limited choice remains.

AA. FIXED-PRICE / PRIX-FIXE MENU

31. **prix-fixe menu = 定價套餐**

A multi-course meal offered for one fixed price, sometimes with choices within individual courses. ([Toast POS][1])

prix fixe is French-derived restaurant vocabulary.

AB. TABLE D'HÔTE

32. **table-d'hôte menu = 定價套餐餐單**

Traditionally a fixed-price meal with a limited selection within courses. ([Toast POS][1])

More formal/traditional hospitality terminology.

AC. TASTING MENU

33. **tasting menu = 品嚐餐單 / 嚐味套餐**

A curated sequence of relatively small courses designed to showcase:

- * chef's style;
- * ingredients;
- * theme;
- * progression.

Restaurant-industry descriptions treat it as a planned sequence of courses rather than ordinary independent ordering. ([Toast POS][1])

AD. DEGUSTATION MENU

34. **degustation menu = 品嚐餐單**

A more formal term, especially in fine dining, closely overlapping with:

> tasting menu.

AE. CHEF'S MENU

35. **chef's menu = 主廚餐單**

Often means:

> a selection determined/curated by the chef.

Exact format varies by restaurant.

AF. MENU DU JOUR

36. **menu du jour = 今日餐單 / 當日套餐**

French-derived phrase meaning broadly:

> menu of the day.

Lower priority in everyday English.

AG. DAILY MENU

37. **daily menu = 每日餐單**

Menu specifically offered on a particular day.

AH. MENU = PLANNED FOOD FOR A MEAL / PERIOD

38. **menu = selection of food planned to be served, not necessarily a printed card**

> "What's on the menu tonight?"

「今晚**吃甚麼 / 今晚的餐單是甚麼**？」

Here there may be no restaurant and no printed menu.

39. **weekly menu = 每週膳食安排**

Used in:

- * schools;
- * hospitals;
- * homes;
- * institutions.

> “We planned the week's menu.”

「我們規劃了這星期的**餐單**。」

AI. SCHOOL MENU

40. **school menu = 學校膳食餐單**

The planned meals offered at school.

AJ. HOSPITAL / INSTITUTIONAL MENU

41. **hospital menu = 醫院膳食餐單**

May include options tailored to dietary needs.

AK. **ON THE MENU** — LITERAL

42. **on the menu = listed and available to order (餐牌上有) **

> “Is soup on the menu?”

「餐牌上有湯嗎？」

AL. **NOT ON THE MENU**

43. **not on the menu = not officially offered (餐牌上沒有) **

> “That dessert isn't on the menu today.”

「今天餐牌上沒有那款甜品。」

AM. OFF-MENU

44. **off-menu item = not listed on the regular menu but possibly available (餐牌以外項目) **

> “They ordered an off-menu dish.”

「他們點了一道**餐牌上沒有列出的菜**。」

Availability depends on restaurant.

AN. SECRET MENU

45. **secret menu = unofficial/unadvertised selection of customizable or hidden offerings (隱藏餐單) **

Often marketing/informal terminology.

Sometimes there is no literal separate menu; it may simply refer to known custom combinations.

AO. **TAKE SOMETHING OFF THE MENU**

46. **take/remove a dish off/from the menu = 停止供應某菜式**

> “They took the sandwich off the menu.”

「他們把那款三文治從餐牌上**撤下 / 停售**。」

AP. **ADD SOMETHING TO THE MENU**

47. **add X to the menu = 把 X 加入餐牌**

> “The café added two new desserts to the menu.”

「咖啡店把兩款新甜品**加入餐牌**。」

AQ. **CHANGE / UPDATE THE MENU**

48. **change the menu = 更改餐牌內容**

May include:

- * new items;
- * removed items;
- * different prices;
- * revised descriptions.

AR. FIGURATIVE MENU = RANGE OF CHOICES

This is the second major semantic branch.

49. **menu = list/range of possible choices (選項清單)**

> “Customers can choose from a menu of services.”

「顧客可以從一系列**服務選項**中選擇。」

The metaphor is:

- > restaurant diner chooses dishes
- > → person chooses among general alternatives.

AS. **MENU OF OPTIONS**

50. **a menu of options = 一系列可供選擇的方案**

> “The software offers a menu of options.”

「軟件提供一系列**選項**。」

This overlaps with the computing sense but can also be purely figurative.

AT. MENU OF SERVICES

51. **menu of services = 服務選項清單**

Common in:

- * business;
- * consulting;
- * healthcare;
- * hospitality.

AU. MENU OF PRODUCTS

52. **menu of products = 一系列可供選擇的產品**

Often figurative/business usage.

AV. MENU OF ACTIVITIES

53. **menu of activities = 可選活動清單**

> “Guests can choose from a menu of activities.”

「客人可以從一系列活動中選擇。」

AW. FIGURATIVE **ON THE MENU**

54. **X is on the menu = X is being considered/available as an option**

> “Expansion is on the menu for next year.”

Approximately:

「明年會考慮**擴展這個選項**。」

Informal/metaphorical.

AX. FIGURATIVE **OFF THE MENU**

55. **X is off the menu = no longer available/considered (不再考慮) **

> “A full redesign is off the menu for now.”

「目前不會考慮全面重新設計。」

This usage is metaphorical, not culinary.

AY. COMPUTING: MENU

A major independent modern branch.

56. **menu = list of commands/options displayed by software or a device (選單 ; 功能表) **

> “Choose Settings from the menu.”

「從**選單**中選擇『設定』。」

This develops directly from:

> restaurant list of choices.

AZ. MENU ITEM — COMPUTING

57. **menu item = individual selectable command/option (選單項目) **

> “Click the Print menu item.”

「按一下『列印』**選單項目**。」

Same compound as restaurant **menu item**, but different domain.

BA. MAIN MENU

58. **main menu = 主選單**

The highest-level menu from which other sections/options can be selected.

Common in:

- * apps;
- * games;
- * devices.

BB. SUBMENU

59. **submenu = 子選單**

A menu opened from another menu.

> menu → submenu → command.

BC. MENU BAR

60. **menu bar = 選單列**

Interface area containing menu headings such as:

- * File
- * Edit
- * View

in traditional desktop software.

BD. DROP-DOWN MENU

61. **drop-down menu = 下拉式選單**

A list of options that opens downward from a control.

BE. PULL-DOWN MENU

62. **pull-down menu = 下拉選單**

Closely related to **drop-down menu**, especially older GUI terminology.

BF. POP-UP MENU

63. **pop-up menu = 彈出式選單**

Menu that appears temporarily at the current interface location.

BG. CONTEXT MENU

64. **context menu = 快捷選單 / 內容功能表**

Menu whose available commands depend on:

> what the user clicked/selected.

Often opened via:

* right-click;

* long press.

BH. RIGHT-CLICK MENU

65. **right-click menu = 右鍵選單**

Everyday term for a context menu opened with the right mouse button.

BI. CASCADING MENU

66. **cascading menu = 級聯式選單**

A submenu opens beside its parent menu, possibly producing multiple levels.

BJ. HAMBURGER MENU

67. **hamburger menu = 漢堡選單**

Interface menu commonly represented by an icon of three horizontal lines:



Clicking/tapping it reveals navigation or options.

The name refers to the icon's visual resemblance to stacked layers.

BK. OVERFLOW MENU

68. **overflow menu = 更多選項選單**

A UI menu containing secondary commands that do not fit in the main interface.

Often represented by:

* three dots.

BL. KEBAB MENU

69. **kebab menu = 垂直三點選單**

Informal UI-design name for:



Used to expose additional commands.

BM. MEATBALL MENU

70. **meatball menu = 水平三點選單**

Informal design term for:

...

Lower priority, but established among UI/design practitioners.

BN. NAVIGATION MENU

71. **navigation menu = 導航選單**

List of links/sections allowing movement through:

- * website;
- * app;
- * system.

BO. APPLICATION MENU

72. **application menu = 應用程式選單**

Top-level menu for application-wide commands.

BP. SETTINGS MENU

73. **settings menu = 設定選單**

Where users adjust application/device preferences.

BQ. START MENU

74. **Start menu = Windows 「開始」選單**

A specific Microsoft Windows interface term.

It gives access to applications, search, settings, power commands, etc., depending on Windows version.

BR. BOOT MENU

75. **boot menu = 開機選單**

Computer firmware/startup menu allowing selection of:

- * boot device;
- * startup options,

depending on system.

This is not a restaurant-derived special meaning beyond the general computing “choice list” sense.

BS. COMMAND MENU

76. **command menu = 指令選單**

A menu containing commands a user can execute.

BT. MENU-DRIVEN

77. **menu-driven = operated primarily by selecting from displayed menus (選單驅動的) **

> “The system uses a menu-driven interface.”

「該系統採用**選單式介面**。」

BU. TEXT MENU

78. **text-based menu = 文字選單**

A menu displayed as textual numbered/lettered options rather than a graphical interface.

BV. TERMINAL / CONSOLE MENU

79. **console menu = 終端選單**

Users choose commands through a text interface.

BW. GAMES

80. **game menu = 遊戲選單**

Examples:

- * main menu;
- * options menu;
- * inventory menu;
- * character menu.

BX. PAUSE MENU

81. **pause menu = 暫停選單**

Displayed when gameplay is paused.

May offer:

- * resume;
- * settings;
- * restart;
- * quit.

BY. CHARACTER / INVENTORY MENU

82. **inventory menu = 物品欄選單**

Displays/selects items in games.

BZ. DVD / DISC MENU

83. **DVD menu / disc menu = 光碟選單**

Interactive screen for selecting:

- * play;
- * chapters;
- * languages;
- * extras.

CA. TV / MEDIA MENU

84. **TV menu = 電視設定選單**

A television/device interface for:

- * picture;
- * sound;
- * channels;
- * network;
- * settings.

CB. PHONE / VOICE MENU

85. **phone menu / telephone menu = 電話語音選單**

An automated telephone system presents choices such as:

> “Press 1 for sales.”

CC. IVR MENU

86. **IVR menu = 互動式語音應答選單**

IVR = **interactive voice response**.

Users choose options by:

- * keypad;
- * speech.

CD. VOICE MENU

87. **voice menu = 語音選單**

A menu communicated through audio rather than visually.

CE. MENU TREE

88. **menu tree = 選單樹狀結構**

Hierarchy showing:

> main menu → submenu → further submenu/options.

Used in:

- * software;
- * phone systems;
- * devices.

CF. MENU STRUCTURE / HIERARCHY

89. **menu hierarchy = 選單層級**

Organization of options into parent and child menus.

CG. RESTAURANT BUSINESS: MENU DESIGN

90. **menu design = 餐牌設計**

Includes:

- * layout;
- * typography;
- * categories;
- * descriptions;
- * visual hierarchy;
- * pricing presentation.

It concerns both usability and commercial presentation.

CH. MENU ENGINEERING

91. **menu engineering = systematic analysis and redesign of a restaurant menu according to factors such as item popularity and profitability (餐牌工程 / 餐單收益分析) **

Restaurant-industry sources describe **menu engineering** as analyzing menu items—especially their popularity and contribution/profitability—and using that information to guide menu pricing, placement and design. ([Toast POS][2])

繁體中文可按教學需要譯為：

餐牌工程

餐單盈利分析

餐牌項目盈利及人氣分析

CI. MENU ENGINEERING MATRIX

92. **menu engineering matrix = 餐牌工程矩陣**

A common restaurant-management framework categorizes menu items according to:

- * popularity;
- * profitability/contribution margin. ([Toast POS][2])

Some industry frameworks use categories such as:

- * stars;
- * puzzles;
- * plowhorses;
- * dogs. ([Toast POS][2])

These are specialized restaurant-management labels, not ordinary meanings of **menu**.

CJ. MENU ANALYSIS

93. **menu analysis = 餐牌分析**

Evaluation of factors such as:

- * sales volume;
- * food cost;
- * contribution;
- * popularity.

CK. MENU PLANNING

94. **menu planning = 餐單規劃**

The process of deciding:

- * what dishes will be served;
- * balance/variety;
- * ingredients;
- * timing;
- * dietary needs;
- * cost.

Used in:

- * restaurants;
- * schools;
- * hospitals;
- * catering;
- * household nutrition.

CL. MENU DEVELOPMENT

95. **menu development = 餐牌開發**

Creating/testing new:

- * dishes;
- * combinations;
- * descriptions;
- * menu structure.

CM. MENU PRICING

96. **menu pricing = 餐牌定價**

Deciding what prices to charge for menu items.

CN. MENU LABELING / LABELLING

97. **menu labeling = 在餐牌上標示營養 / 熱量等資料**

Regulatory/public-health/business term.

Depending on jurisdiction, menus may be required to show certain information such as calorie values or allergen-related information.

The specific requirements vary by jurisdiction.

CO. ALLERGEN MENU / ALLERGEN INFORMATION

98. **allergen menu = 致敏原資訊餐牌**

A menu or supplementary document showing potential allergens in dishes.

CP. ECONOMICS: MENU COST

Now a major specialist metaphor.

99. **menu cost = cost a firm incurs when changing its prices (調價成本 ; 菜單成本) **

Economists use **menu costs** for the costs involved in changing prices—for example the literal cost of replacing restaurant menus, extended to broader administrative, system and implementation costs of repricing. A Federal Reserve source explicitly explains that the term comes from the analogy with restaurants changing printed menu prices. ([聯邦儲備系統][3])

CQ. MENU COSTS

100. **menu costs = 調整價格的固定 / 實務成本**

Possible examples include:

- * printing new labels;
- * changing catalogues;
- * updating systems;
- * staff/admin work.

The term is broader than actual restaurant menus.

CR. MENU-COST MODEL

101. **menu-cost model = 菜單成本模型 / 調價成本模型**

Macroeconomic models use the idea that firms face costs when adjusting prices, which can contribute to price stickiness. Federal Reserve research continues to use **menu cost models** in this established technical sense. ([聯邦儲備系統][4])

CS. PRICE STICKINESS

102. **menu costs and price rigidity**

If changing prices has a meaningful cost, firms may leave prices unchanged even when economic conditions move somewhat.

This is part of the economics **menu-cost** branch, not a new lexical sense.

CT. ECONOMICS / CONTRACT THEORY: MENU OF CONTRACTS

103. **menu of contracts = set of alternative contracts/options from which another party selects**

Specialist economics/mechanism-design language.

The metaphor remains:

> restaurant menu → selectable alternatives.

****繁體中文：****

*** **合約選項組合****

*** **可選合約清單****

CU. CHOICE ARCHITECTURE

104. **menu of choices = structured set of available alternatives**

In decision design/business contexts, the “menu” determines:

> what choices are presented.

So changing the menu can change behavior even if individual options remain voluntary.

CV. **A FULL / WIDE MENU OF OPTIONS**

105. **a wide menu of X = many alternatives (多種選擇) **

> “The service provides a wide menu of training options.”

「該服務提供多種培訓選項。」

This use is figurative and slightly formal/business-like.

CW. **A LIMITED MENU OF OPTIONS**

106. **limited menu = limited range of choices**

Can be literal food:

> limited food menu

or figurative:

> limited menu of solutions.

CX. MENU VS DISH

menu

entire list/range of offerings.

dish

one prepared food item.

> menu contains dishes.

Do not translate:

> “I ordered a menu.”

unless ****menu**** in that particular regional context means a set meal.

In general English:

> order a dish/item ****from the menu****.

CY. MENU VS MEAL

****menu****

list/planned selection.

****meal****

food actually eaten on an occasion.

A menu describes possible/planned food; it is not necessarily the food itself.

CZ. MENU VS RECIPE

****menu****

what dishes are offered.

****recipe****

instructions/ingredients for preparing one dish.

> menu says “roast chicken”

> recipe explains how to cook it.

DA. MENU VS FOOD LIST

****food list**** is understandable but not the usual restaurant term.

****menu**** is conventional.

DB. MENU VS PRICE LIST

menu

primarily dishes/drinks, normally often including prices.

price list

a list emphasizing prices for products/services.

A menu can function partly as a price list, but the concepts differ.

DC. MENU VS CATALOGUE / CATALOG

catalogue

organized collection/list of products/items, often much broader.

menu

selection of immediately available choices.

In computing, **menu** normally presents actions/options rather than a complete catalogue.

DD. MENU VS LIST

list

any ordered/grouped collection of items.

menu

a list specifically meant to support **selection**.

That choice function is central across all branches:

> food choices → service choices → computer commands.

DE. MENU VS OPTIONS

options

the individual possibilities.

menu

the structured set from which the options are selected.

> menu contains options.

DF. MENU VS TOOLBAR — COMPUTING

menu

opens/displays a list of commands.

toolbar

shows buttons/icons for commands directly.

A program may contain both.

DG. MENU VS DIALOG BOX

menu

select one command/option from a list.

dialog box

window/panel used to enter information or configure settings.

Selecting a menu item may open a dialog box.

DH. MENU VS NAVIGATION

navigation menu

specifically moves users between sections/pages.

general menu

may contain any commands, not merely navigation.

DI. MENU VS SUBMENU

menu

any selectable list.

submenu

secondary menu opened from an item in another menu.

DJ. DROP-DOWN MENU VS COMBO BOX

Often confused.

drop-down menu

list of commands/options appearing from a menu/control.

combo box

UI control combining a field/current value with a selectable drop-down list.

Technical interface distinction.

DK. CONTEXT MENU VS MAIN MENU

main menu

general top-level options.

context menu

options relevant specifically to the object/current context.

DL. MENU BOARD VS MENU

menu board

the display medium.

menu

the information/offerings.

A menu board displays the menu.

DM. SET MENU VS À LA CARTE

set menu

courses bundled into a predetermined/fixed-price arrangement.

à la carte

dishes selected/priced individually.

Restaurant-industry glossaries maintain this basic distinction. ([Toast POS][1])

DN. SET MENU VS TASTING MENU

set menu

fixed selection or limited course choices, usually value/meal structure focused.

tasting menu

curated sequence, often many smaller courses, designed to showcase culinary ideas.

They can overlap, but they are not automatically identical.

DO. SPECIAL VS OFF-MENU ITEM

special

temporary dish/promotion, which may be officially advertised.

off-menu item

not listed on the regular menu.

A special can still appear on:

> today's specials board/menu.

DP. SECRET MENU VS OFF-MENU

off-menu

simply not listed.

secret menu

often popularly known unofficial options/custom combinations.

Not every restaurant genuinely maintains a formal “secret menu.”

DQ. **WHAT'S ON THE MENU?**

107. Literal

> “What's on the menu tonight?”

= 「今晚有甚麼菜？」

108. Figurative

Can mean:

> “What choices/plans are available?”

> “What's on the menu for today's workshop?”

= 「今天工作坊安排了甚麼？」

Informal metaphor.

DR. ****MENU FOR THE DAY****

109. literal

food planned/offered that day.

110. figurative

sometimes humorous:

> list of activities/events planned for the day.

DS. GRAMMAR

111. ****on the menu****

> steak is on the menu.

Not usually:

> *in the menu* ❌

when meaning “listed as an available dish.”

Use:

> ****on the menu****.

DT. ****FROM THE MENU****

112. ****order/choose something from the menu****

> “Choose anything from the menu.”

「餐牌上的東西你可以任選。」

DU. **A MENU OF + PLURAL NOUN**

113. figurative construction

- > a menu of services
- > a menu of options
- > a menu of activities.

Meaning:

- > a selectable range.

DV. **MENU FOR + OCCASION**

114.

- > menu for the wedding
- > menu for tonight
- > menu for the week.

DW. COUNTABILITY

Restaurant menu

Countable:

- > a menu
- > two menus.

Computing menu

Countable:

- > open a menu
- > several menus.

Figurative range

Countable:

> a menu of alternatives.

Economics: menu costs

Usually plural compound:

> **menu costs**

rather than ordinary singular food sense.

DX. FAMILY / EXTENSION MAP

Branch	Main meaning
-----	-----
menu — restaurant content	list/range of dishes and drinks available
menu — physical object	card, sheet, board, etc. displaying those offerings
menu — planned food	dishes intended for a meal/day/week
on/off the menu	available or unavailable as food
menu — figurative	structured range of alternatives
menu — computing	displayed list of selectable commands/options
menu — phone/device	spoken or displayed choice hierarchy
menu engineering	restaurant analysis of menu performance/design
menu cost — economics	cost of adjusting prices
menu of contracts/options	technical/general set of alternatives from which one chooses
submenu	secondary menu contained under another menu
menu-driven	system operated mainly through menus

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
menu — restaurant	列出可供顧客選擇的食物、飲品及通常其價格的餐牌 / 菜單
menu — physical document	顧客手上 / 牆上實際展示菜式的餐牌、紙張或板
handwritten menu	以手寫方式列出菜式的餐牌
menu item — food	餐牌上其中一項可點的菜式 / 飲品
menu section	starters、mains、desserts 等餐牌分類
menu board	在櫃檯 / 牆上展示餐牌內容的餐牌板
digital menu	屏幕、平板、網站等顯示的電子餐牌

QR menu	掃描二維碼後開啟的電子餐牌	
online menu	在網站 / App 上提供的網上餐牌	
takeaway/delivery menu	外賣 / 配送可供點選的餐單	
breakfast/lunch/dinner menu	早餐 / 午餐 / 晚餐時段餐牌	
dessert menu	甜品餐牌	
drinks/beverage menu	飲品餐牌	
kids' menu	為兒童設計的餐牌	
seasonal menu	隨季節 / 食材供應改變的餐牌	
à-la-carte menu	每款菜獨立選擇及一般獨立定價的單點餐牌	
set menu	預先安排的菜式組合，通常以一個套餐價出售	
prix-fixe menu	以固定總價提供多道菜的定價套餐	
table-d'hôte menu	固定價錢、各道菜只有有限選擇的傳統套餐形式	
tasting menu	由主廚編排多道小份菜式的品嚐餐單	
degustation menu	較正式用語：品嚐餐單	
menu — planned meal	一餐 / 一天 / 一週所安排供應的菜式組合	
on the menu — literal	正式列於餐牌，可供點選	
off-menu item	沒有正式列在餐牌上的菜式	
secret menu	未公開列出但顧客可能知道可以要求的非正式選項	
take X off the menu	把某某菜式從供應餐牌撤下	
add X to the menu	把某新菜式加入正式供應	
menu — figurative	可供選擇的一系列方案 / 服務 / 活動	
a menu of options	一組有系統地提供給人選擇的選項	
on the menu — figurative	被納入可考慮 / 可採用的選擇	
off the menu — figurative	暫不再屬於可考慮選項	
menu — computing	電腦 / 裝置介面上讓使用者選擇命令或功能的選單	
menu item — computing	選單中的一項命令 / 功能	
main menu	系統 / 程式最高層的主選單	
submenu	從另一選單開出的次級選單	
menu bar	放置 File、Edit 等選單標題的選單列	
drop-down menu	點擊後向下展開選項的下拉式選單	
context menu	根據目前所選物件 / 位置提供相關命令的快捷選單	
hamburger menu	常以三條橫線圖示打開的導航 / 功能選單	
navigation menu	用來前往網站 / App 不同部分的導航選單	
settings menu	調整系統 / App 設定的選單	
Start menu	Windows 的「開始」選單	
boot menu	開機時選擇啟動裝置 / 方式的選單	
pause menu	遊戲暫停後顯示的功能選單	
DVD/disc menu	影片光碟的播放、章節、語言等選單	
phone/voice menu	自動電話系統用語音提供的選項清單	
menu-driven	主要靠逐層選擇選單操作的	
menu tree/hierarchy	主選單、子選單等形成的層級結構	
menu design	餐牌的版面、字體、分類、描述及資訊設計	
menu engineering	按菜式人氣及盈利等資料分析和改善餐牌的餐飲管理方法	
menu planning	規劃將供應哪些菜式及其組合	
menu pricing	決定餐牌各項目的售價	
menu costs — economics	公司更改價格時產生的實務 / 固定成本；名稱源自餐廳重印餐	

牌			
menu-cost model		以改價有成本解釋價格不頻繁調整等現象的經濟模型	
menu of contracts		經濟學等領域供另一方選擇的一組合約方案	

For your original passage

> “Many people imagine warm lighting, the handwritten ****menu**** and the smell of fresh pastries...”

The exact sense is:

> ****a physical restaurant/café menu listing the drinks, food and prices, presented in an attractive handwritten style.****

It also performs an important rhetorical job.

The writer deliberately chooses three sensory/visual details:

- > warm lighting
- > handwritten menu
- > fresh pastries

to represent:

> ****the picturesque customer-facing image of café ownership.****

But immediately afterward comes the hidden operating reality:

- > rent
- > renovation
- > wages
- > waste
- > licensing
- > suppliers
- > slow Tuesdays.

So ****menu**** here is literal, while its role in the paragraph is symbolic:

> ****the attractive front-facing side of the café business.****

For your core database, I would keep ****5 principal semantic branches****:

1. ****restaurant list of dishes/drinks****
2. ****the physical/display object carrying that list****
3. ****planned selection of food for a meal or period****
4. ****figurative structured range of choices****
5. ****computer/device/telephone list of selectable commands or options****

Then separately index the highly established extensions **set menu, à la carte, tasting menu, menu item, on/off the menu, submenu, menu bar, drop-down/context/hamburger menu, menu-driven, menu engineering, and menu costs**, because these are too conventional to hide under the single gloss 「餐牌」.

[1]: https://pos.toasttab.com/blog/on-the-line/restaurant-terms?utm_source=chatgpt.com
"Restaurant Menu Terms Glossary: À la carte, Prix Fixe, Du Jour & More Explained"

[2]: https://pos.toasttab.com/resources/restaurant-menu-engineering?utm_source=chatgpt.com
"The Menu Engineering Course | Toast POS"

[3]: https://www.federalreserve.gov/SECRS/2011/March/20110308/R-1404/R-1404_030811_69120_621655419027_1.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com "Microsoft Word - Consumer Impact Final 22Feb2011.doc"

[4]: https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/feds/nonlinear-dynamics-in-menu-cost-economies-evidence-from-u-s-data.htm?utm_source=chatgpt.com "The Fed - Nonlinear Dynamics in Menu Cost Economies? Evidence from U.S. Data"